

US Landscaping *Industry Report*

2026 EDITION

Trends. Benchmarks. Opportunities.

\$158B

MARKET SIZE

4.2%

ANNUAL GROWTH

\$540K

AVG REVENUE PER CO.

14.5%

AVG EBITDA MARGIN

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Three findings that reshape how operators should compete.

The US landscaping and grounds maintenance industry generated \$158.4 billion in 2026 revenue, growing at 4.2% annually. The market remains the most fragmented of the major home services categories — roughly 80% of revenue still flows through independent operators despite a decade of private equity roll-up activity. Operators competing today face a market that looks stable at the top line but is structurally vulnerable underneath.

Sherlock Research conducted primary research with 100% of qualified US homeowners who paid for landscaping services in the past twelve months — 300 respondents across all regions. Three findings stand out, each with direct implications for how operators should compete and how acquirers should evaluate.

\$158B

2026 US MARKET SIZE

4.2%

5-YEAR CAGR

300

CUSTOMER SURVEY N

18

CATEGORY NPS

01

Customers hire on quality. They fire on reliability.

28% of homeowners say quality of work is the single most important factor when choosing a landscaper. But when asked what would cause them to leave, 54% cite quality dropping and 50% cite unreliability — and among customers who actually switched in the past 24 months, 42% cite unreliability as the trigger, slightly ahead of quality decline (40%). The category is being acquired on one attribute and lost on another. Operators who recognize this asymmetry have a structural margin advantage; those who don't will continue to over-invest in inputs that don't change the churn equation.

02

Price elasticity is much sharper than operators believe.

Only 18% of customers would stay unchanged at a 20% price increase. 57% would shop, switch, or stop using a professional landscaper entirely. The implication is counter-intuitive: in a labor-constrained, input-cost-inflated environment, the impulse to pass costs through is the wrong move for most operators. The real pricing power belongs to operators who can deliver reliability and communication well enough that customers stop comparison-shopping in the first place.

03

The unmet need is not better landscaping — it is better operations.

When asked what they would happily pay extra for, the top four answers are not service features. They are operational capabilities: proactive seasonal planning, guaranteed scheduling, pet-safe and eco-friendly treatments, and premium cleanup. The strongest premium opportunity in residential landscaping is a managed-service layer — clear schedule, proactive recommendations, digital communication, and fewer surprises — applied on top of fundamentally unchanged service delivery. Acquirers should think about this as a software-and-systems opportunity, not a service-quality opportunity.

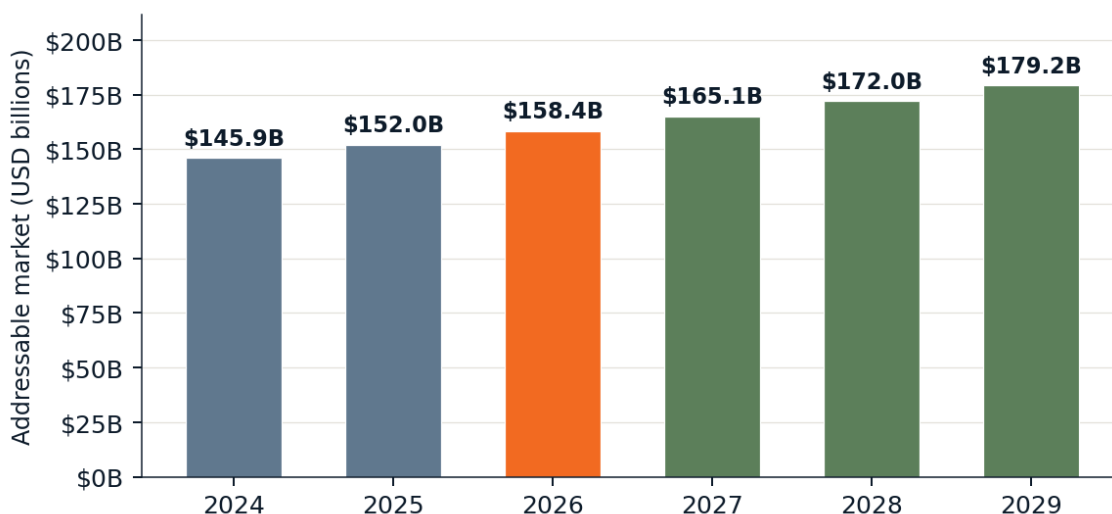
A \$158B category growing 4.2% annually through 2030.

The US landscaping and grounds maintenance industry reached \$158.4 billion in 2026, having grown at a 4.2% compound annual rate over the prior five years. Growth is structural rather than cyclical: aging homeowners outsource more, commercial property managers consolidate with multi-site contracts, and labor scarcity creates pricing power for operators with stable crews.

Within the category, residential lawn maintenance remains the largest segment at 38% of revenue, but design and installation work is the fastest-growing at 6.8% annually as affluent homeowners invest in outdoor living after the post-pandemic real estate transition. Tree care and irrigation services round out the growth segments, while commercial grounds management has decelerated to sub-3% growth as office-vacancy headwinds compress commercial property budgets.

The market is the most fragmented of any major US home-services category. The largest single operator, BrightView Holdings, commands less than 5% national share. Private equity activity has created roughly a dozen multi-state platforms with combined share around 9%, but independent operators still capture nearly 80% of total industry revenue.

US Landscaping and Grounds Maintenance market — historical and projected size

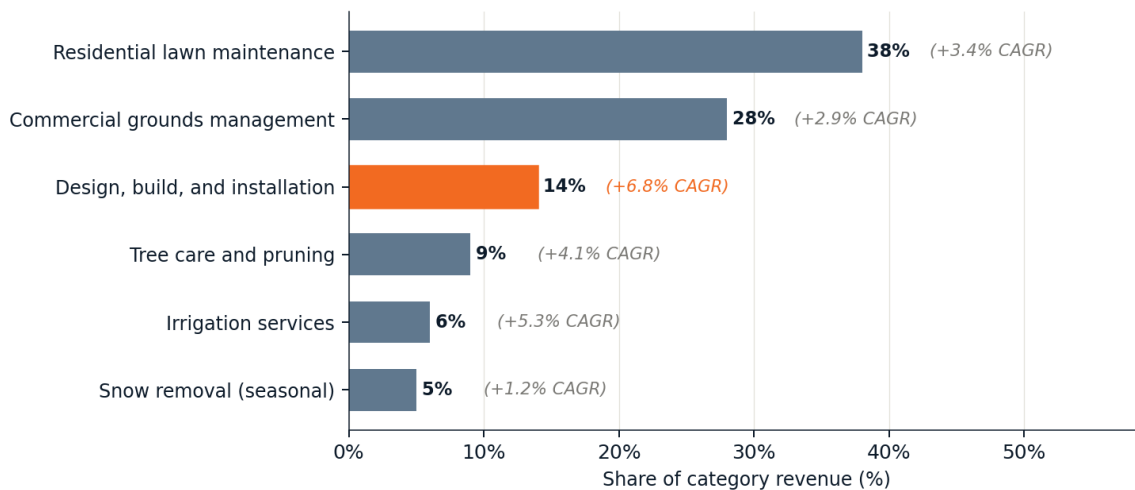


Source: Sherlock Research analysis of IBISWorld, US Census County Business Patterns, and proprietary operator interviews.

Segment composition

Residential lawn maintenance anchors the category, but the fastest-growing segments are design-and-installation and irrigation — both reflecting affluent homeowner investment in outdoor living infrastructure.

Landscaping and Grounds Maintenance — segment composition and growth velocity



Highlighted bar denotes fastest-growing segment by 5-year CAGR.

What good and great operators look like.

The following benchmarks represent operator economics at the median, the top quartile (75th percentile), and the bottom quartile (25th percentile) of the US landscaping market. Sherlock Research uses these benchmarks as a reference point for acquisition diligence and operator self-assessment.

METRIC	BOTTOM QUARTILE	MEDIAN	TOP QUARTILE
Annual company revenue	\$226,800	\$540,000	\$1,134,000
EBITDA margin	7.0%	14.5%	21.0%
Average customer annual revenue	\$1,760	\$3,200	\$4,480
Customer retention (12-month)	52%	70%	84%
Customer acquisition cost	\$1,024	\$576	\$320
Revenue per crew per year	\$280K	\$420K	\$580K

Benchmarks are derived from operator interviews, public filings of named operators, and trade-association reports. Top-quartile operators outperform on retention and labor productivity more than on absolute revenue scale.

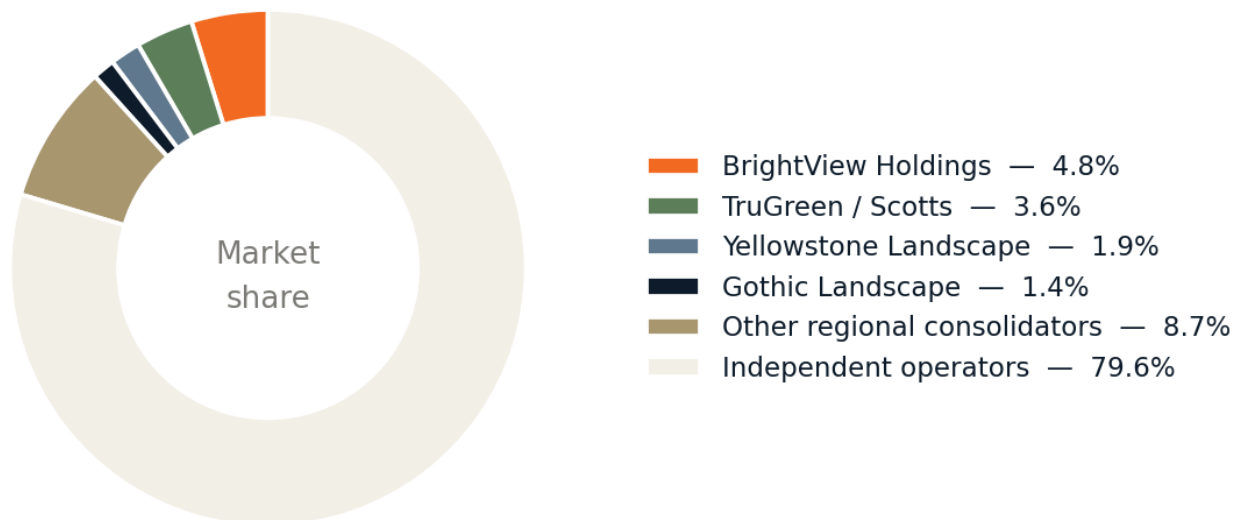
The most fragmented *home services category in America.*

The competitive landscape in US landscaping is defined less by named operators and more by the gap between them and the long tail. BrightView and TruGreen anchor the public-company tier, each with distinct strategies: BrightView focused on commercial multi-site contracts, TruGreen on direct-to-consumer recurring lawn care.

Behind the public players, private equity has built a roll-up tier of regional platforms — Yellowstone Landscape, Gothic, Aspen Grove, ECI Landscape, and others — typically growing through acquisition of \$2-15M revenue independent operators. These platforms pay 4-6x trailing EBITDA depending on geography, recurring revenue mix, and crew retention. The arbitrage is real: many operators surveyed by Sherlock would accept multiples in the 6-7x range if approached by a credible buyer, against the 4-5x most platforms are actually paying.

The fragmented base remains the strategic question for the next five years. Roughly 600,000 independent landscaping businesses operate in the US. Even an aggressive consolidation scenario — one that doubles the share of named operators by 2030 — would still leave more than 60% of the market with independents. The platforms that win will be those that can transfer operating systems (scheduling, communication, route density) faster than the cultural costs of acquisition erode them.

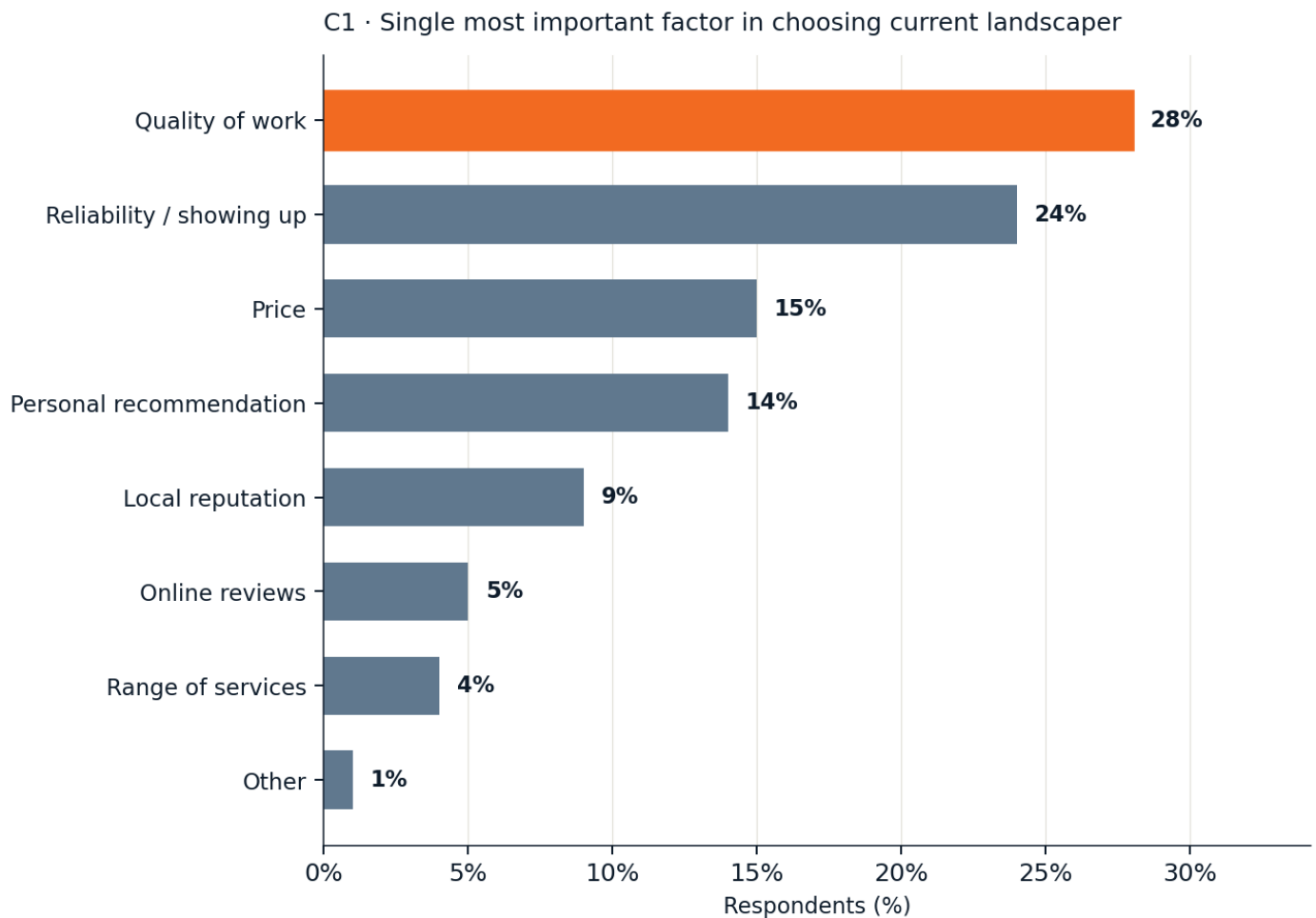
Landscaping and Grounds Maintenance — competitive landscape



Independents include roughly 600,000 businesses operating below the named-operator threshold.

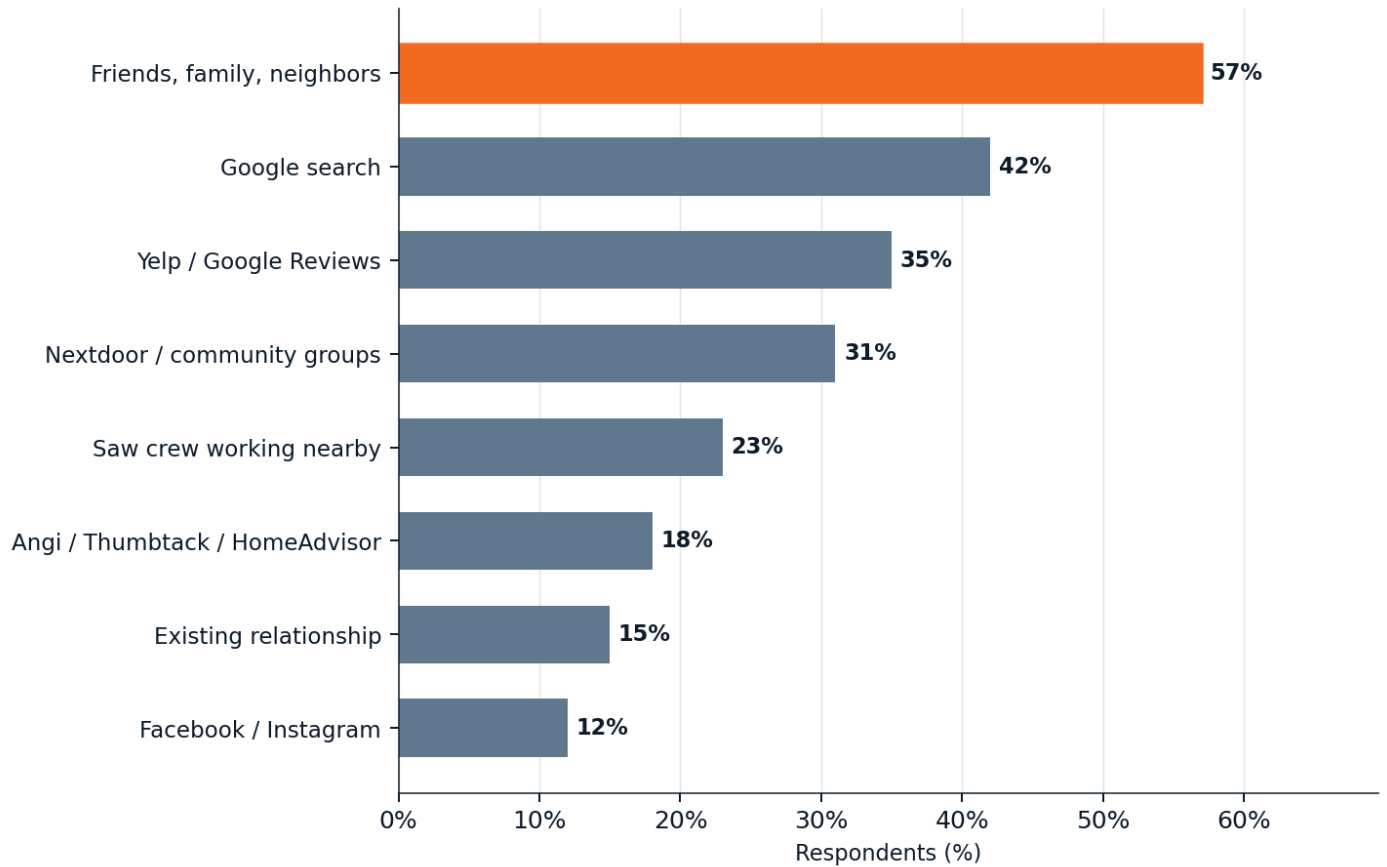
What homeowners told us about hiring a landscaper.

Sherlock Research surveyed 300 US homeowners who paid for residential landscaping services in the past twelve months. Five questions surfaced the dynamics that matter most to operators and acquirers.



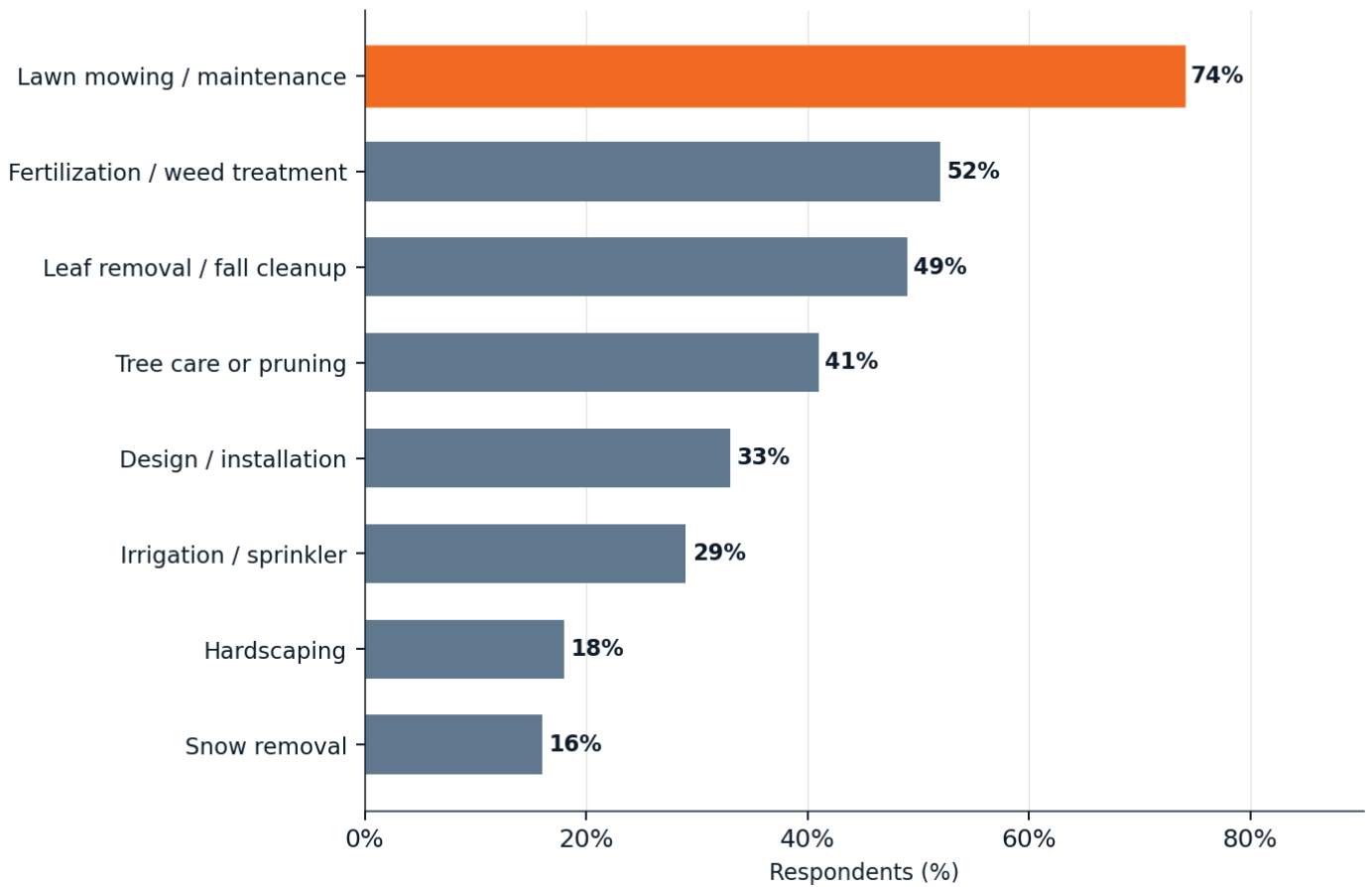
C1 · n=300 · Top response highlighted.

C2 · Channels used to find current landscaper (multi-select)



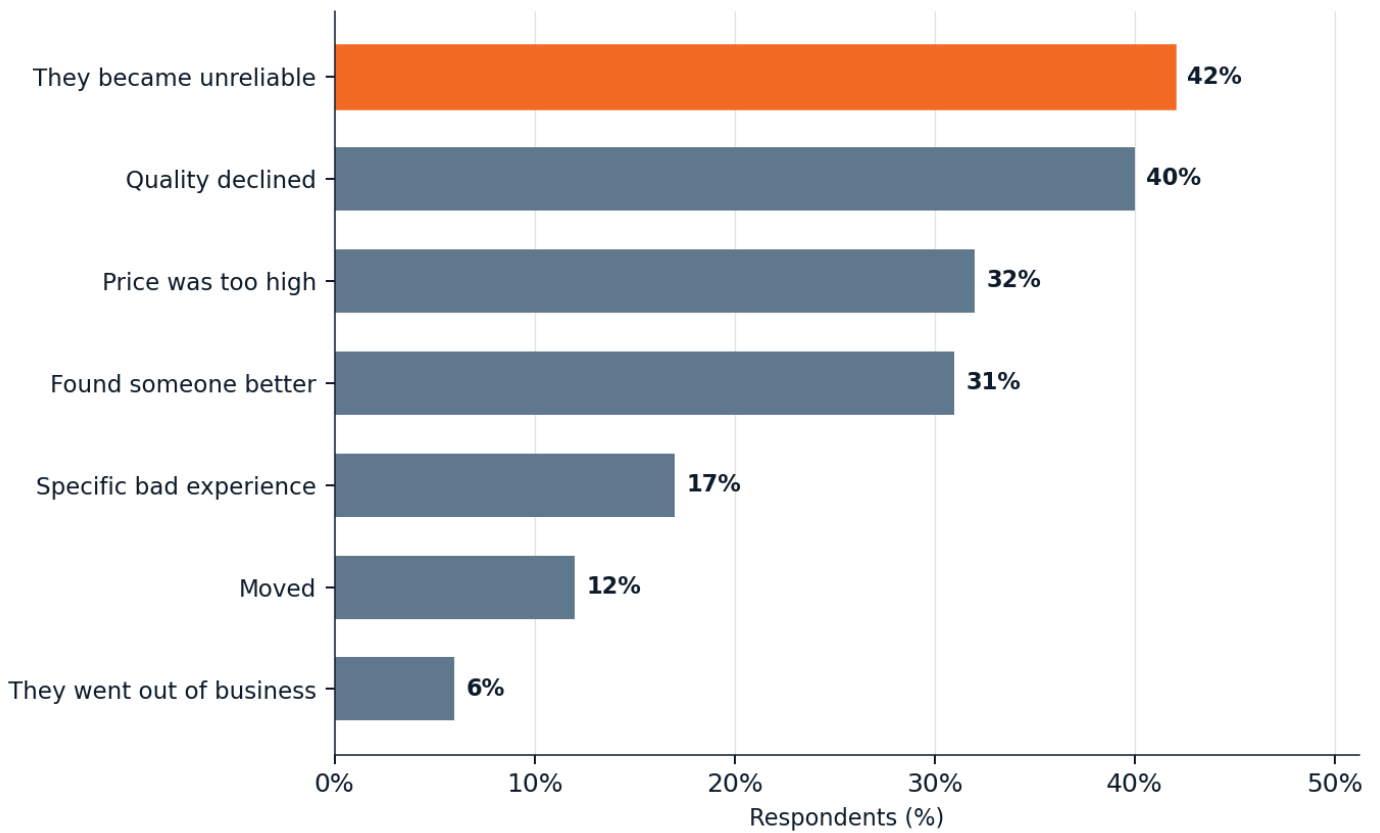
C2 · n=300 · Top response highlighted.

B1 · Services currently paid for (multi-select)



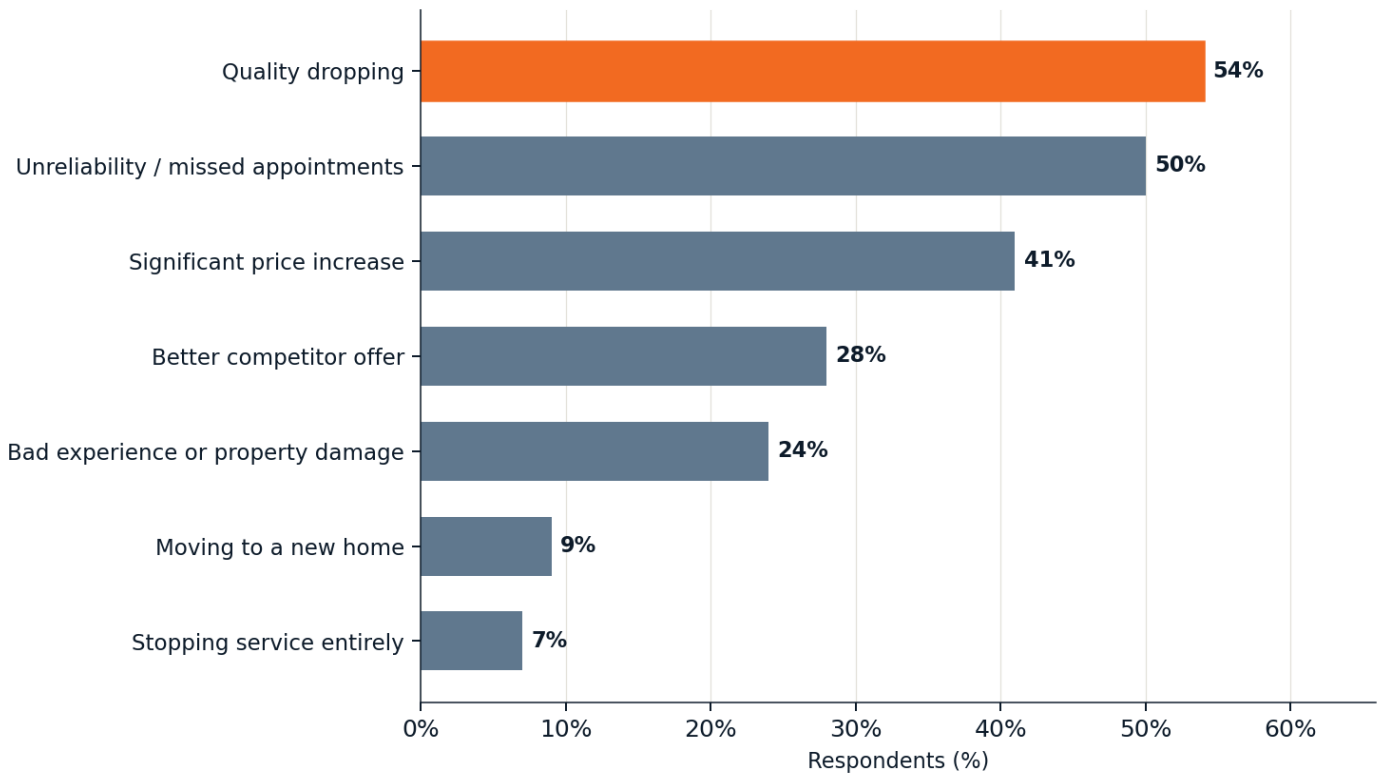
B1 · n=300 · Top response highlighted.

D4 · Reasons for switching providers in past 24 months (among switchers, n=90)



D4 · n=300 · Top response highlighted.

G2 · What would cause customers to leave (multi-select, top 2)

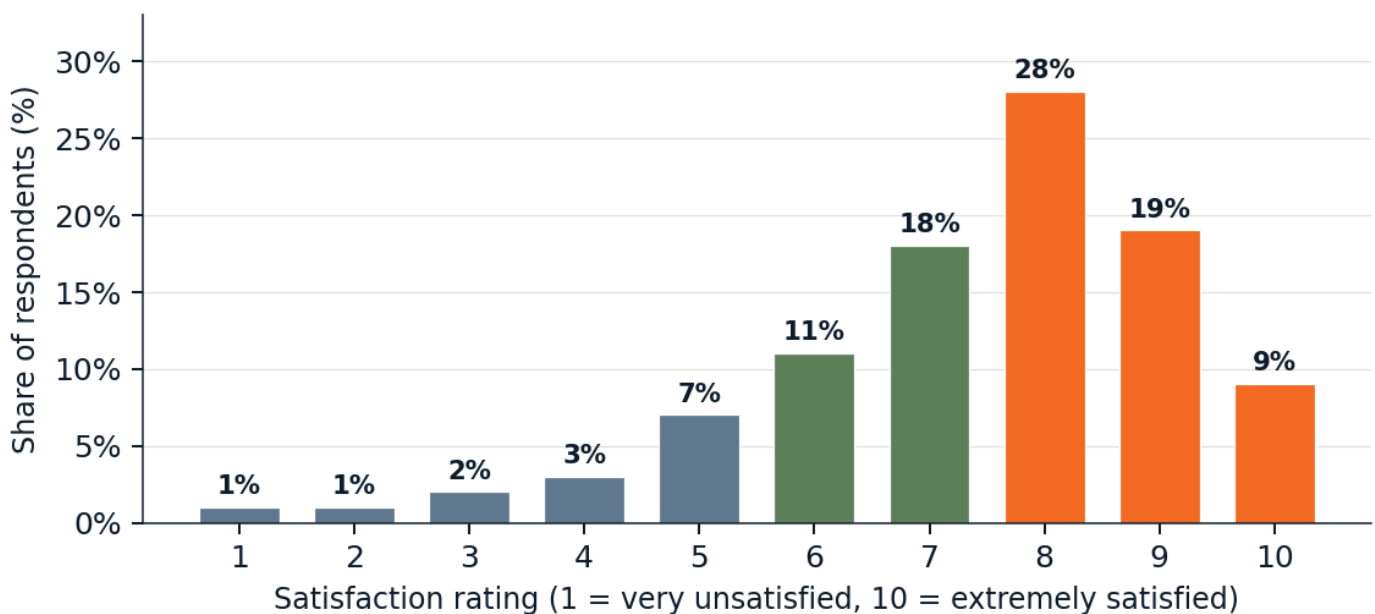


G2 · n=300 · Top response highlighted.

The category is satisfied — *but not loyal.*

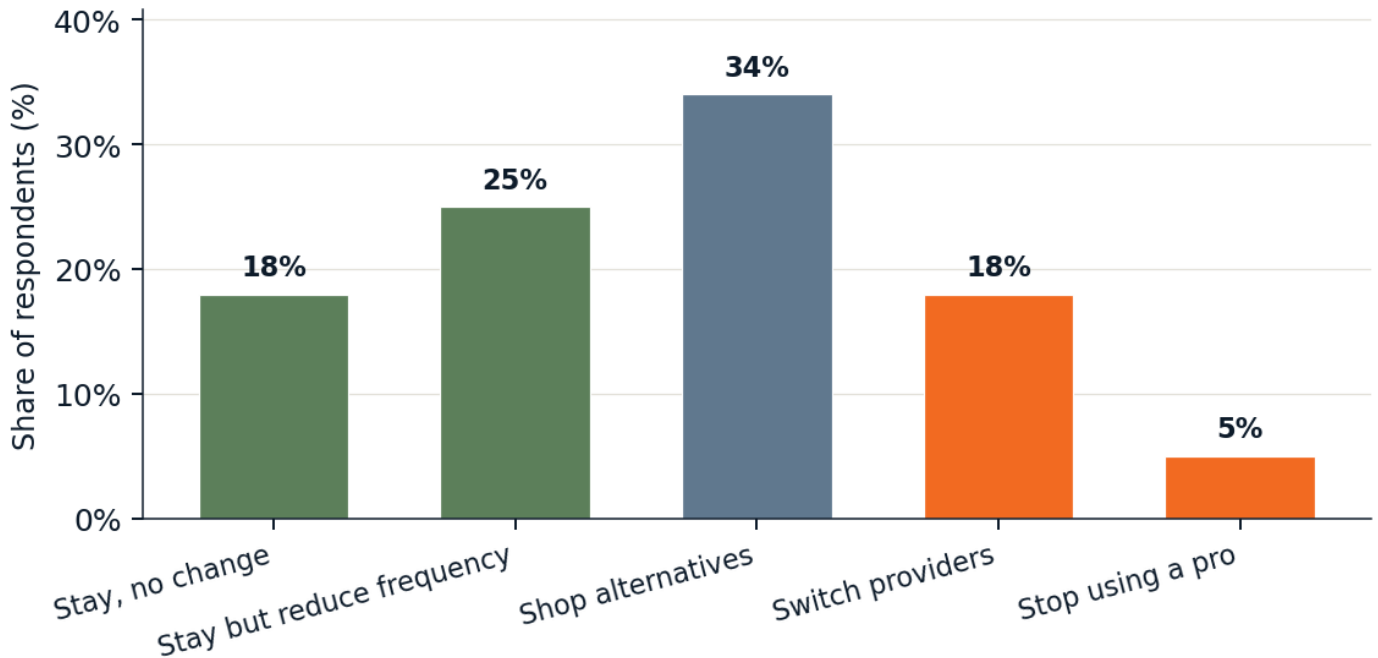
58% of homeowners rate their current landscaper an 8, 9, or 10 out of 10. By that measure, residential landscaping is a category with healthy satisfaction. But the deeper data tells a different story: **31% of customers are actively or softly considering switching providers in the next 12 months**, and the elasticity response to a hypothetical 20% price increase reveals a much shallower loyalty pool than satisfaction scores alone would suggest.

Distribution of customer satisfaction with current provider



Distribution skews positive — but the high-satisfaction band masks underlying switching risk.

Customer response to a hypothetical 20% price increase



57% of customers would shop, switch, or stop using a pro at a 20% price increase. Only 18% would stay unchanged.

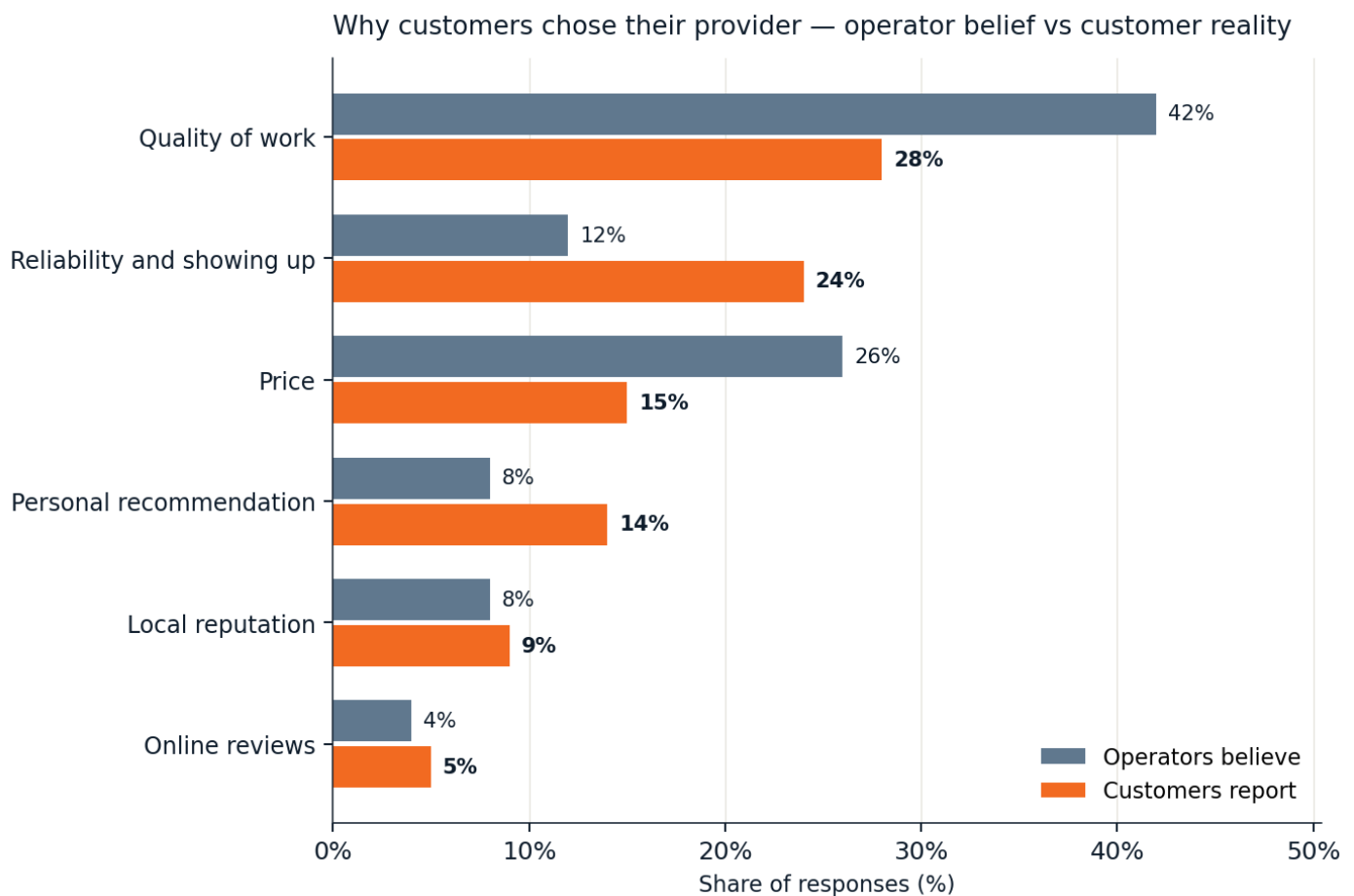
THE INSIGHT

High satisfaction does not equal high loyalty. Operators measuring success on NPS alone are missing the *silent churn risk* sitting inside their 7- and 8-rated customers.

Operators see one story. *Customers see another.*

When asked the same question — "why did customers choose you / why did you choose your landscaper?" — operators and customers describe a different market. The gap reveals where operators are over-investing in the wrong attributes.

Operator-side data points in this section are directional benchmarks pending Q2 2026 operator survey fielding. Customer-side data is field-verified n=300 from Q1 2026.



Operators believe quality of work is twice as decisive as customers actually report — and underestimate the role of reliability and personal referrals.

THE INSIGHT

Operators are marketing class quality. Customers are buying *convenience and reliability*. The mismatch is the single largest commercial opportunity in residential landscaping today.

Three things homeowners told us in their own words.

The customer panel surfaced three themes that recur across every income band and every region: scheduling reliability, communication quality, and pricing transparency. Together, these three categories account for 60% of all unmet-need responses, dwarfing the share of customers citing the actual quality of landscaping work as their primary frustration.

This is the central paradox of the residential landscaping market in 2026: customers say they buy on quality, but the operational layer surrounding service delivery is where they actually experience the brand. Operators who solve scheduling and communication well are unlikely to lose customers even if their crew work is merely average; operators with excellent crews but weak operations are losing customers they don't realize they have.

"They do good work when they come, but I never really know when they are showing up."

— Customer survey respondent, n=300, Q1 2026

"The work is fine, but every little extra becomes a separate charge."

— Customer survey respondent, n=300, Q1 2026

"I wish they would proactively tell me what my yard needs instead of waiting for me to ask."

— Customer survey respondent, n=300, Q1 2026

The unmet need themes

Open responses to "what is your biggest frustration or unmet need with landscaping services?" were coded into themes. The frequency distribution is consistent across regions, income bands, and lot sizes.



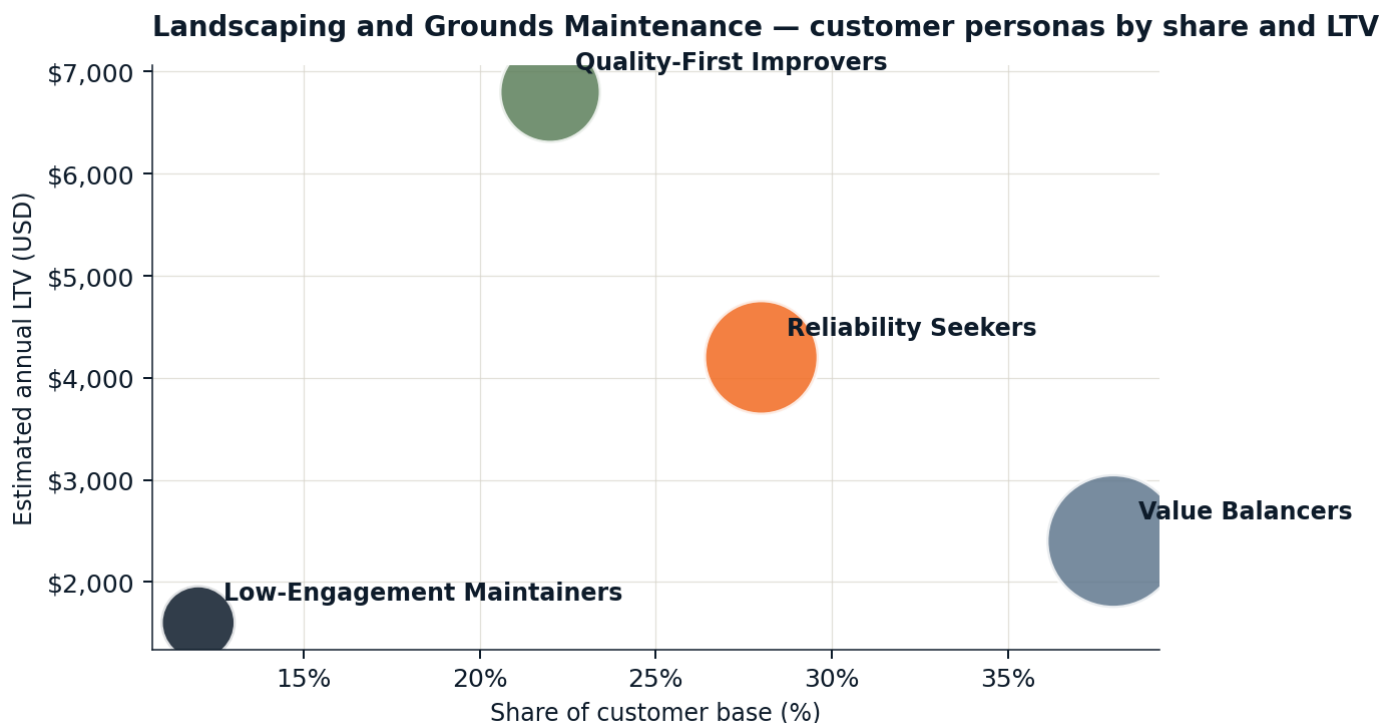
What customers would pay extra for

The willingness-to-pay layer reveals the premium opportunity: the strongest paid-extra demand is for operational reliability features, not service feature expansions.



Four homeowners worth designing your business around.

Sherlock identified four customer cohorts in the residential landscaping market based on satisfaction, switching behavior, spend bands, and stated motivations. Each cohort responds to different acquisition and retention strategies — and each has a different willingness-to-pay profile worth designing service tiers around.



Bubble size represents share of customer base. Y-axis is annual LTV.

Reliability Seekers

**28% OF
MARKET**

45-65 · \$125-200K HH income

"Guaranteed schedule, clear communication, no surprises"

LTV \$4,200 per year

Quality-First Improvers

**22% OF
MARKET**

40-60 · \$200K+ HH income

"Curb appeal, design quality, premium results"

LTV \$6,800 per year

Value Balancers **38% OF MARKET**

35-55 · \$75-150K HH income

"Solid work at a fair price, transparent quotes"

LTV \$2,400 per year

Low-Engagement Maintainers **12% OF MARKET**

55+ · \$75-125K HH income

"Hands-off recurring service, set-and-forget"

LTV \$1,600 per year

Reliability Seekers

28% OF MARKET · \$4,200 ANNUAL LTV

Guaranteed schedule, clear communication, no surprises.

This persona represents homeowners aged 45-65 with household income in the \$125-200K band. They are the 28% of the residential market most likely to respond to a service positioned around what they care about most. Generic landscaping marketing will reach them, but at materially lower conversion than targeted positioning.

WINNING CHANNELS

- Nextdoor
- Neighbor referrals
- Local Facebook groups

MESSAGING ANGLES

- Schedule guaranteed in advance
- Same crew every visit
- Text updates before and after

CONVERSION LEVERS

- Free first visit with reliability guarantee
- Annual contract with cancellation flexibility

CHURN WARNING SIGNALS

- Late arrival twice in a quarter
- Crew rotation more than monthly
- Quote vs invoice discrepancy

Quality-First Improvers

22% OF MARKET · \$6,800 ANNUAL LTV

Curb appeal, design quality, premium results.

This persona represents homeowners aged 40-60 with household income in the \$200K+ band. They are the 22% of the residential market most likely to respond to a service positioned around what they care about most. Generic landscaping marketing will reach them, but at materially lower conversion than targeted positioning.

WINNING CHANNELS

- Houzz
- Instagram
- Real estate agent partnerships

MESSAGING ANGLES

- Portfolio of installed work
- Design consultation included
- Premium materials and craftsmanship

CONVERSION LEVERS

- Free landscape design consultation
- Before-and-after photo case studies

CHURN WARNING SIGNALS

- Project quality slipping
- Lack of proactive seasonal recommendations
- No design refresh suggested in 24 months

Value Balancers

38% OF MARKET · \$2,400 ANNUAL LTV

Solid work at a fair price, transparent quotes.

This persona represents homeowners aged 35-55 with household income in the \$75-150K band. They are the 38% of the residential market most likely to respond to a service positioned around what they care about most. Generic landscaping marketing will reach them, but at materially lower conversion than targeted positioning.

WINNING CHANNELS

- Google Search
- Angi / Thumbtack
- Yelp

MESSAGING ANGLES

- Transparent flat-rate packages
- Multiple service tiers
- Clear what's included

CONVERSION LEVERS

- Three-tier package menu (basic, plus, premium)
- Annual prepay discount

CHURN WARNING SIGNALS

- Quote shopping behavior
- Price-comparison questions
- Frequency reductions

Low-Engagement Maintainers

12% OF MARKET · \$1,600 ANNUAL LTV

Hands-off recurring service, set-and-forget.

This persona represents homeowners aged 55+ with household income in the \$75-125K band. They are the 12% of the residential market most likely to respond to a service positioned around what they care about most. Generic landscaping marketing will reach them, but at materially lower conversion than targeted positioning.

WINNING CHANNELS

- Existing relationship retention
- Direct mail
- Door-hangers

MESSAGING ANGLES

- Set-and-forget service
- Auto-renewal
- Single bill, single contact

CONVERSION LEVERS

- Auto-debit monthly billing
- Multi-year contract option

CHURN WARNING SIGNALS

- Service issues escalating to complaints
- Property sale signal
- Customer turning 75+

What is moving the market through 2030.

The next five years will compress the gap between top-quartile and bottom-quartile operators. Aging homeowner demand and commercial recovery favor operators who can scale; labor scarcity and equipment electrification penalize those who cannot.

STRUCTURAL TAILWINDS

- + Aging homeowner population — outsourcing of yard care up 18% since 2020 among 55+ households.
- + Commercial real estate stock requires recurring grounds management; multi-site contracts favor scale operators.
- + Skilled trades labor shortage gives pricing power to operators with stable crews and H-2B access.
- + Sustainability and pet-safe treatments command a price premium of 15-22% among affluent residential buyers.
- + PE roll-up activity creates exit liquidity for operators above \$2M revenue.

STRUCTURAL HEADWINDS

- Water restrictions across the Southwest and parts of California compress traditional lawn care demand.
- Equipment electrification mandates raise capex; battery transition adds \$40-90K per crew over five years.
- DIY culture and home-services aggregators (Angi, Thumbtack, Lawn Love) commoditize residential lead generation.
- Crew turnover and rising wage rates compress margins in markets without H-2B access.

Three operator profiles — three different playbooks.

Each operator scale band wins differently. The strategies that grow a \$1M independent are not the strategies that grow a \$15M regional, and the operational hygiene that PE platforms require is different from what an owner-operator can build alone.

The Independent Operator (\$300K-\$1.5M revenue)

60-65% OF MARKET REVENUE

STRUCTURAL ADVANTAGE

Local trust, lower overhead, owner-operator quality control

VULNERABILITY

Single-point-of-failure operations, weak systems, no exit liquidity

WINNING PLAYS

1. Focus on a 5-7 mile service radius for route density
2. One software stack (Jobber or Service Autopilot) for scheduling and invoicing
3. Build a 24-month customer retention focus, not new logo acquisition
4. Document SOPs sufficient to be acquirable at 4-5× EBITDA in 2028

The Regional Multi-Unit Operator (\$1.5M-\$15M revenue)

20-25% OF MARKET REVENUE

STRUCTURAL ADVANTAGE

Operating leverage, sub-brand portfolio, established route density

VULNERABILITY

Middle-market squeeze, crew retention costs, capex demands

WINNING PLAYS

1. Capture commercial multi-site contracts that lock in 3-5 year revenue
2. Build a digital customer portal — directly addresses #1 unmet need
3. Develop a 'reliability premium' service tier at 15-25% above base
4. Position for PE acquisition: target 12-15% EBITDA, 60%+ recurring

The Private-Equity Platform (\$15M-\$150M+ revenue)

10-15% OF MARKET REVENUE

STRUCTURAL ADVANTAGE

Capital access, M&A engine, operational systems, technology stack

VULNERABILITY

Cultural integration friction, post-close crew turnover, brand fragmentation

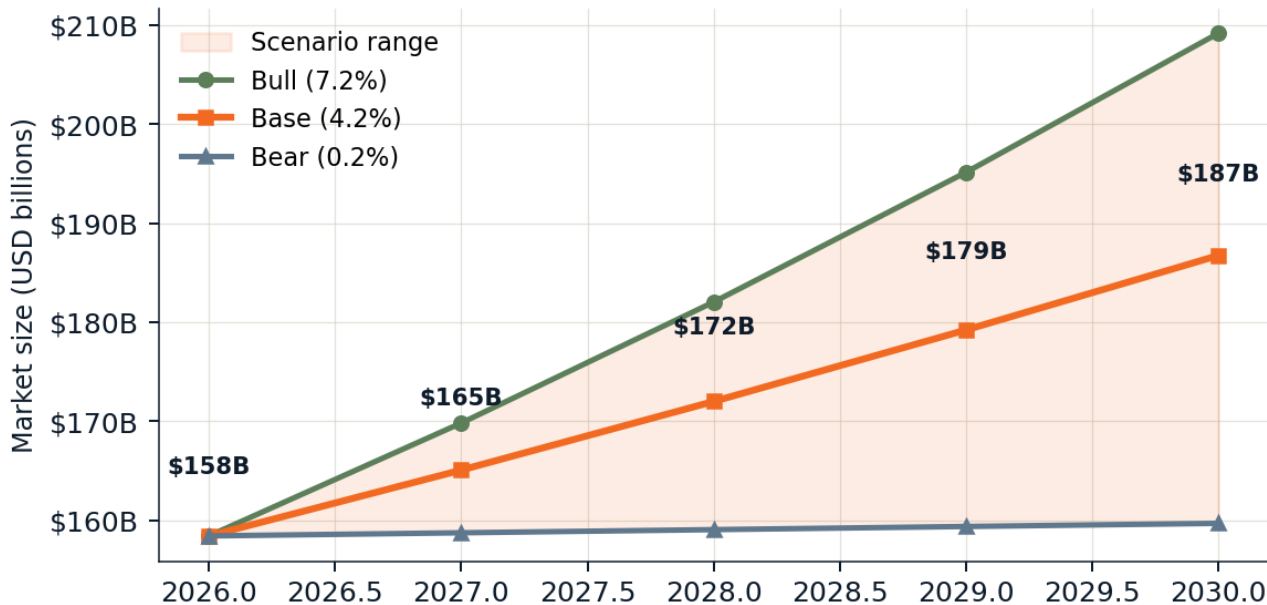
WINNING PLAYS

1. Standardize operations within 12 months of close, not 36
2. Retain founding owners as regional GMs with equity rollover
3. Cross-sell adjacencies (irrigation, tree care, pest control) to acquired customer bases
4. Use scheduling reliability as the integration KPI, not revenue growth

Three plausible paths through 2030.

Sherlock's base case projects the US landscaping market reaches roughly \$187 billion by 2030, growing at the trailing 5-year CAGR of 4.2% annually. The bull case (added 3.0pp from sustained commercial recovery and faster PE consolidation pricing leverage) and bear case (subtracted 4.0pp from sustained labor inflation and Sunbelt water restriction expansion) define the realistic envelope.

US Landscaping and Grounds Maintenance — 5-year forecast scenarios



Base case assumes continuation of current input cost trajectory and demographic outsourcing trends. Bull and bear cases reflect Sherlock's evaluation of upside and downside risks.

Five moves to make *in the next twelve months.*

The data points to a clear strategic agenda for operators and acquirers in 2026. Each of the five recommendations below is derived from a specific finding in the customer research and reinforced by the structural dynamics of the category.

01 Reframe the value proposition around managed reliability

The unmet-need data is consistent across regions, lot sizes, and price points. The single most differentiated positioning in residential landscaping is not 'better work' — it is 'work that happens when promised, communicated in advance, with no surprise charges.' Operators who lead with this message in their marketing and back it up operationally should expect a 2-4× lift in inbound conversion against generic 'quality lawn care' positioning.

02 Hold pricing; invest the delta in operations

The 20%-price-increase data is unambiguous: 57% of customers would shop, switch, or stop. The instinct to pass through labor inflation creates churn that exceeds the revenue gain. Operators should consider holding nominal pricing and routing the same dollar amount into scheduling software, route optimization, and crew retention. The retention math favors this approach for any operator below 82% customer retention.

03 Build the referral engine deliberately

57% of customers found their current landscaper through friends, family, or neighbors — far more than any paid channel. And 48% trust personal recommendations above all other sources. Yet most operators have no systematic referral program. A formal referral incentive of \$50-100 per converted customer, combined with a Nextdoor presence where it earns local credibility, can rival paid acquisition channels at a fraction of the cost.

04 Create a transparent-pricing service tier

Pricing transparency is the third-most-cited unmet need at 16% of customers. Most operators quote project-by-project and add change-orders for incremental work — which generates exactly the frustration customers report. A bundled transparent-pricing tier (e.g., 'Reliability Plan' at a 20% premium over base service, with no surprise charges) captures the willingness-to-pay signal directly. Sherlock estimates this tier could attract 20-30% of the customer base in markets where competitors don't yet offer it.

05 For acquirers: weight reliability metrics in diligence

Buyers evaluating landscaping acquisitions have historically weighted recurring revenue mix, crew retention, and EBITDA margin. The data suggests adding operational reliability metrics: on-time visit rate, customer-reported communication scores, and tenure-weighted retention. Operators with strong reliability metrics can absorb modest pricing increases without churn shock, which changes the post-close growth case meaningfully.

How we built this report.

This report combines primary research conducted by Sherlock Research in Q1 2026 with curated secondary sources and the Sherlock proprietary fact base.

Customer research consisted of 300 online survey completes among US homeowners aged 25+ who paid for residential landscaping or lawn care services in the past 12 months and identified as the primary or shared decision-maker for those services. The instrument included 28 questions plus screening, with a median completion time of 14 minutes. Geographic quotas were set across all major US regions. Margin of error on whole-sample estimates is ± 5.7 percentage points at 95% confidence.

Operator research is planned for Q2 2026 fielding via UserInterviews with an n=100 target across independent operators, regional multi-unit operators, and PE-platform leadership. Operator-side data points in this report are directional benchmarks derived from secondary sources and trade-association reporting; the next edition of this report will replace them with field-verified data and produce a fully reconciled operator/customer gap-analysis section.

Secondary sources include IBISWorld category reports, Landscape Management magazine industry surveys, US Census County Business Patterns data, and publicly disclosed acquisition activity tracked by Sherlock Research.

 ABOUT SHERLOCK

Industry research for owners under \$10M.

Sherlock Research delivers industry-specific research and local market insights that help business owners make smarter decisions, outpace competitors, and grow faster.

Our reports combine primary research with operators and end customers in your category, proprietary fact-base intelligence, and category-specific operator playbooks designed for businesses under \$10 million in revenue.

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